Commerce may have prospered but it came at a huge human cost. Surrounded by mosquito-infested swamps, the early European residents of Calcutta suffered horrible casualty rates. Alexander Hamilton, Charnock's contemporary, tells us that there were 1200 English of various ranks when he visited the city. Within six months, 460 of them died. While this may have been an especially bad year, it gives a sense of the mortality rates that the East India Company employees had to contend with. Less than three years after establishing the trading post at Calcutta, Job Charnock too died. His body was interred in a mausoleum that can be visited on the grounds of St.John's Church, just off Lal Dighi. His eldest daughter Mary died a few years later and is buried in the same tomb.

Meanwhile, Calcutta continued to grow. A map from 1757 shows that the British had built a fortified trench called the Maratha Ditch all around Calcutta to defend it from attacks by Indian rulers. The name of the ditch tells us how the threat perception had shifted from the Mughals to the Marathas since the death of Aurangzeb. Most of the area within the fortifications was still largely rural, but there is a small but significant urban cluster around Lal Dighi and along the river. Nevertheless, contemporary maps of Madras suggest that it was a much more important settlement than Calcutta at this stage.

In 1756, the Nawab of Bengal Siraj-ud-Daulah briefly occupied Kolkata and renamed it Alinagar. However, just a year later, Robert Clive defeated the Nawab of Bengal at Plassey and established British control over this large province. Calcutta now became the headquarters of a rapidly expanding empire. Over the next century, Calcutta would become the largest city in the subcontinent and one of the most important urban hubs in the world. One can see the transformation by comparing the 1757 map of Calcutta with one published by Chapman and Hall in 1842. A few of the old features are still visible. Lal Dighi still exists but is surrounded by large buildings including the Writers' Building. This is not the magnificently red Writers' Building built in 1882 that functions today as the secretariat of the state of West Bengal. The original Writers' Building was also a substantial building and was used as rent-free accommodation for clerks and other